Stephen Dossou

Mines Paris – PSL, CERNA
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Citizenship: Benin

Research Fields

Primary: Entrepreneurial Finance, Venture Capital
Secondary: Contract Theory and Mechanism Design, Applied Econometrics

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA, ED SDOSE) 2024 – expected 2027
Advisors: Pierre Fleckinger and Philippe Mustar

Diplôme d'Ingénieur (M.Sc. equivalent), CentraleSupélec 2020 – 2024
Information & Communication Engineering. Optimization, machine learning, network theory, quantitative modelling.

Classes Préparatoires (MPSI, MP*), Lycée Louis-le-Grand, Paris 2018 – 2020
Competitive undergraduate programme in advanced mathematics and physics.

Visiting Positions

Visiting Ph.D. Student, Imperial College Business School, London Oct. – Nov. 2026
Host: Ramana Nanda.

Honors and Awards

Ranked 1st nationwide, *Baccalauréat* série C (science track), Benin 2017

Ranked 1st nationwide, *BEPC* (lower-secondary national examination), Benin 2014

Job Market Paper

"Protection and Dilution: SAFEs and MFN Clauses in Seed Financing"

I ask how an accelerator should protect its stake against the seed investor who finances its startups next, and what a most-favored-nation (MFN) clause, such as the $375,000 uncapped MFN SAFE that Y Combinator added to its standard deal in 2022, is worth to it. In my model, the accelerator spends its contribution before a liquidity shock, a seed investor with market power covers the rest with a priced or an unpriced SAFE, and competitive investors fund the projects worth scaling. Without protection, the seed investor takes all the equity of the projects it finances. A fixed post-money share gives the accelerator this share of every project the seed investor finances. Any fixed share that comes with a contribution is strictly beaten by an MFN clause with a small MFN component, which takes more from small rounds than from large ones. The seed investor answers with an unpriced SAFE and invests beyond its need in the smallest rounds. Numerically, for software-like projects, the accelerator puts almost all of its money through the clause, which gives the highest profit and the highest total surplus. For deep-tech

projects, the accelerator buys its fixed share for almost no money, and this share lowers the total surplus below the first best, which the absence of protection reaches. *JEL:* G24, G23, D86.

WORKING PAPERS

"Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions"

- Venture capital contracts are bargained deal by deal with entrepreneurs, but contracts between institutions are not: an accelerator committing to a venture capitalist, or a venture capitalist committing to a limited partner, faces non-negotiable terms and often commits blind. In an informed-principal framework, when the principal reveals the project's expected outcome *after* the investor has committed, as between an LP and a VC, an optimal pooling mechanism exists and the budget constraint is slack in cash-rich economies, so every profitable project is financed. When revelation comes *before* the commitment, as between an accelerator and a VC, the unique optimal mechanism is again pooling, but the budget constraint binds in every economy and some positive-NPV projects are necessarily excluded. The observed uniformity of institutional terms is therefore an equilibrium object rather than an administrative convenience. *JEL:* G24, G23, D82, D86.

"Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital"

- Nothing in the UK's withdrawal restricted co-investment, yet continental venture capitalists whose pre-determined reliance on British partners was above the median cut the share of their syndicates including a British investor by 8.2 percentage points against a base rate of 18.7% ($p < 0.001$), from the semester of the referendum onwards. The effect is confined to the relational margin: deal counts, stages, round sizes, follow-on financing and exits are all null, established British ties dissolve no faster than comparable continental ones (triple difference $+0.3$ pp, $p = 0.77$), and aggregate UK–continental volume tracks the rest of Europe. Exposure-based event study on Crunchbase, wild-cluster bootstrap inference.

POLICY REPORTS

"Devenir ETI : les chemins de la croissance" June 2025
with Pierre Fleckinger, Philippe Mustar and Antoine Prévet.
Chaire etilab, Mines Paris – PSL. Report on the growth of French SMEs into mid-sized firms, based on statistical analysis of INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files, accessed through the CASD.

PRESENTATIONS

Imperial College Business School, London November 2026
Protection and Dilution: SAFEs and MFN Clauses in Seed Financing

EARIE (European Association for Research in Industrial Economics), Mannheim August 2026
Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

Internal doctoral workshop, Mines Paris – PSL (CERNA) July 2026
Avoiding the British: Brexit and Partner Choice in European Venture Capital

IOEA (Institute of Organizational Economics Academy), Cargèse April 2026
Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

Journée des Doctorants (joint with Université Paris-Dauphine), Mines Paris – PSL March 2026

Pooling Contracts between Venture Capital Institutions

TEACHING

Microeconomics (undergraduate, first-year engineering cycle) 2024 – 2026
Teaching assistant (*travaux dirigés*), Mines Paris – PSL. Two academic years (2024–2025, 2025–2026); 6 hours of tutorials per year plus exam grading.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, Mines Paris – PSL Jan. 2024 – Oct. 2024
Research on startups and mid-sized firms in France; construction and analysis of large firm-level financial datasets.

Business Analyst (apprenticeship), Forvia Sept. 2022 – Jan. 2024
Digital transformation initiatives in an industrial environment; operational monitoring tools.

Marketing Analyst (internship), Manda Sept. 2021 – Jan. 2022
Acquisition strategy and performance analytics.

Data Scientist (internship), Onogone July – Aug. 2021
Development and evaluation of NLP models.

SKILLS

Methods: Panel and event-study designs, difference-in-differences and triple differences, wild-cluster bootstrap inference with few clusters, falsification and placebo protocols, mechanism design and optimal control.

Software: Python, R, LaTeX, Matlab.

Data: Crunchbase; construction of investor–round and dyad-level panels (>1.2M investor–round observations). Security clearance for confidential statistical data (*habilitation au secret statistique*) and accredited user of the CASD (*Centre d'accès sécurisé aux données*); work on INSEE's FARE firm-level accounting files.

LANGUAGES

French (native), English (C1).

REFERENCES

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